laughing. Disarmingly, he said that if I continued with the current plan, I would end up emerging as a sportswoman after the Yatra. But I think he told the other yatris to check on me, and a couple of people did so every day. To the point that one day, the newly elected Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge approached me to enquire about any discomfort or leg pain I might be suffering from! It could have been just a coincidence, but I was overwhelmed by the kindness he showed to all yatris.

This sensitivity was again brought to our attention when Ganesh ji, a fellow yatri from Tamil Nadu, suffered a fatal cardiac arrest in Maharashtra. It cast a pall over the entire Yatra because we had all become so close. We were so excited in the first two days in Maharashtra (because of the night-time torch march and the qualitatively better arrangements), but all that enthusiasm went out of the window when we lost Ganesh ji. We all felt it as a personal loss and everyone was very upset. Senior leaders such as Digvijaya Singh and Ashok Chavan were trying their best to comfort us, even though they had spent the whole night in the ICU with Ganesh ji.

But what gave us solace and comfort was when the next day, as Ganesh ji's body was transported in the ambulance to his final resting place, Rahul Gandhi paid his respects. After spending over an hour in homage, he left for his tent, only to return swiftly. He gently opened the casket, and tenderly kept looking at Ganesh ji. He didn't say anything, but we could all see how visibly he was moved. He gently hugged some yatris who were beside themselves, and comforted us, even though he himself was so affected. I don't know why, but I immediately remembered images of Rajiv Gandhi comforting Rahul ji after Indira Madam's brutal assassination. In that instance, the depth of Rahul ji's compassion became apparent to everyone. Even though the loss was felt strongly, its sting was lessened by his humanity.

I started observing Rahul ji much more closely: when he met recently graduated students, dressed in graduation robes and carrying a placard around their necks saying 'We are unemployed'; when he met survivors of rape and acid attacks; when he met young children; when he met forty women workers availing of work under the Mahatma Gandhi National